

While and during

Teaching guide

Connect activities that overlap in time.

Understand the distinction

While commonly introduces a clause: while I was cooking. During is a preposition followed by a noun phrase: during dinner. Both can locate something within another period or event.

While cooking is also possible when the understood subject is clear. While does not require a continuous tense in every context: while I am away is natural. During does not say how long an action lasted; use for with a duration.

Compare the patterns

WHILE + CLAUSE

The phone rang while I was cooking.

A subject and verb follow while.

DURING + NOUN

The phone rang during dinner.

Dinner names the event.

FOR + DURATION

We talked for an hour.

An hour measures the duration.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the word meaning at some point in the meeting: I took notes ____ the meeting.

- A. during
- B. for
- C. while

2. Choose the correction: During I was reading, it began to rain.

- A. While during I was reading, it began to rain.
- B. While I was reading, it began to rain.
- C. During reading I was, it began to rain.

3. Which phrase states a measured duration: during the lesson or for an hour?

- A. for an hour
- B. Both phrases give a measured length of time.
- C. during the lesson

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. A call interrupted your lunch preparation. Which sentence connects the two events correctly?

- A. A friend called while I was making lunch.
- B. A friend called during I was making lunch.
- C. A friend called while was I making lunch.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. during

The meeting is a noun phrase.

B: For the meeting can mean intended for it; during identifies when the note-taking happened.

C: While normally introduces a clause here. The meeting is a noun phrase.

2. B. While I was reading, it began to rain.

I was reading is a clause.

A: Use while before the clause; do not add during.

C: The clause needs its usual order: I was reading, introduced by while.

3. A. for an hour

During identifies the surrounding event; for gives the length.

B: Only for an hour gives a measured duration.

C: This identifies the period when something happened, not its measured length.

4. A. A friend called while I was making lunch.

While introduces the background clause I was making lunch.

B: During takes a noun phrase; while introduces this clause.

C: Use normal statement order after while: I was making lunch.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-04.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

A call interrupted your lunch preparation. Which sentence connects the two events correctly?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.